Lead PM Conversation: Practice Roleplay

Transcript · October 20, 2026

Situation

My lead PM spends too much time trying to solve technical problems that should be handled by the engineering team. He has a technical background, so he is quick to respond when incidents are logged and often able to diagnose and resolve them quickly. This presents two problems: ambiguity in roles, and less time for product-focused work, which is critical to the team's success and to setting an example for more junior PMs.

My diagnosis

Hiring mismatch. Feedback has been provided and roles have been clarified, but the behavior has continued.

Roleplay setup

Claude played the lead PM: technically strong, proud of how quickly he resolves incidents, and likely feeling that his firefighting is valued and keeps things running.

Transcript

YOU (LEADER)
On Friday you responded to a technical incident which was assigned to the engineering team, which created a delay in response time.

LEAD PM (Claude)
Wait, a delay? I had that diagnosed in about twenty minutes, and the on-call engineer hadn't even acknowledged the ticket yet. I'm not sure how jumping in made things slower.

YOU (LEADER)
We've spoken about the need for you to refrain from jumping in on engineering tasks. That creates ambiguity in roles which impacts team dynamics.

LEAD PM (Claude)
I hear you, but honestly, what am I supposed to do, watch customers sit with a broken feature when I know how to fix it? If the engineers were responding faster I wouldn't need to step in, so it feels like I'm getting dinged for caring about the outcome.

YOU (LEADER)
We all care about the customers, but as an organization we can only truly succeed when we do our part to maintain the org structure that has been established. If there is a need for engineering to hire more or better quality engineers, they won't see the signals if their productivity data indicates that their incidents continue to be resolved (even when they're not resolved by their team).

LEAD PM (Claude)

Okay, I hadn't thought about it hiding the gap on their side, that's fair. But you're basically asking me to let something stay broken so the numbers tell the right story, and I'm the one who'll hear about it when customers complain. And if I'm being honest, fixing incidents is where I actually feel useful lately.

YOU (LEADER)
Would you like to join the engineering team?

LEAD PM (Claude)
Hold on, is that a real question or are you telling me I'm in the wrong job? I like the technical work, sure, but I took this role to grow in product, and I didn't think we were having a "do you belong here" conversation this morning.

YOU (LEADER)
Not at all. I'm asking that question because you said that you feel most useful when you're solving problems. We have plenty of problems to solve within our team. If you feel more useful solving technical problems, I need to know.

LEAD PM (Claude)
Okay, fair, I appreciate you asking it straight. I think the truth is, an incident has a clear finish line and I know I'm good at it, while the product work feels slower and fuzzier, and I'm not always sure what "doing it well" looks like to you. I don't want to switch teams, but I'd probably stop reaching for incidents if I knew what winning looked like on the product side.

YOU (LEADER)
That's good feedback. If you'll recall, we've documented a strategic plan, a 5-year vision and a portfolio roadmap. When we shared them with your product teams, we spoke about what winning looks like. We covered the Playing to Win concepts to help provide clarity. *[Shared the Playing to Win table: Winning aspiration, Where to play, How to win, Capabilities required, Management systems.]*

LEAD PM (Claude)
Yeah, I remember the Playing to Win session, and I actually agree with the where-to-play choices. But that's the company's version of winning; it doesn't tell me what you'd want to see from me in a given week, or how I'd know I'm doing it well. The management systems row is the part I've never really seen show up for my role. What are the two or three things you'd actually measure me on?

YOU (LEADER)
How successful are you in conveying the expected outcomes for this year as presented in your product roadmap? That can be measured using a feedback loop between you, your product team and the engineering team.

How consistent are you in producing metrics that tell the story of how effective teams are in delivering the value customers expect? Establish a strong customer feedback loop with supporting metrics that tell the story.

LEAD PM (Claude)
Okay, that's more concrete than I've heard before, and honestly the customer metrics piece is something I've let slide. If I'm going to own those, I'd want us to agree on what "good" looks like, like a

monthly readout to you, so I'm not guessing. And I need something from you too: if I stop jumping on incidents, I need to know engineering has a real escalation path, because I'm not going to sit quietly if a customer's down for hours.

YOU (LEADER)

Sounds good. Schedule some time for a monthly readout. I've shared our team's observations and risks with the Engineering Lead. I'll have another candid conversation with him. There may be a need to escalate to Executive Leadership.

LEAD PM (Claude)

Okay, I'll get the monthly readout on the calendar and bring a first draft of the customer metrics so we can react to something real. And thanks for taking the engineering side to their lead; I'll hold back on incidents, but I'd like to hear how that conversation goes so I'm not left wondering whether anything changed.

YOU (LEADER)

I'll certainly share updates.

LEAD PM (Claude)

Sounds good. Honestly, this went better than I expected when you opened with Friday; I'll send over a time for the readout later today.